Divine Europe[1]

Jean Baudrillard

It is clear that if this time the vote is against, they will make us vote and revote until it is approved, as was the case in Denmark and Ireland (so, we should vote "yes" right off the bat. . .)

This leaves us all the freedom to ask ourselves about the no vote in April and on the causes of this tenacious and silent dissent. Because this in itself is a big event. As a yes vote is nothing but an inexorable normalization, only the no vote is a mystery. A "no" which is not at all that of its official proponents, whose political reasoning is as heteroclite as that of the defenders of the "yes" vote. In any case, the negative vote inspired by politics would never have been enough to excite the polls, and it is precisely this vote that slowly gives into the pressure of the vote in favor.

The most interesting and most passionate thing in this referendum of visual illusion is the "no" vote hiding behind the official "no," the "no" beyond political reasoning. It is this vote that resists, and there must be something very dangerous that mobilized all those energies, all those powers mistaken for a defense of the yes vote. This distressing conspiracy is the sign that something is wrong under the surface.

This rejection is obviously an automatic and immediate reaction to the ultimatum that this referendum was from the very beginning. A reaction to this coalition of good conscience, of divine Europe, which makes claims to the universal and does not allow for error, a reaction to the categorical imperative of the "yes" whose promoters did not suppose even for a moment that the "yes" vote could present itself as a challenge — a challenge yet to be seen. It is then not a no to Europe, it is a no to the yes, as unquestionable evidence.

No one can stand the arrogance of an *a priori* victory — no matter what its causes (which in the case of Europe are no more than virtual). Everything is decided in advance, and consensus is all that is being solicited. Yes to the yes: behind this already banal formula hides a terrible mystification. The very yes is no longer a yes to Europe, not even a yes to Chirac or to the liberal order. It is a yes to the yes, to the consensual order, a yes which is no longer a response, but the content of the question itself.

What we are going through is a real test of Europositivity. And this unconditional yes generates spontaneously, by a simultaneous reaction of pride and self-defense, an equally unconditional no. I would say that the real mystery is that the reaction for the

1. This article appeared in *Libération* (May 17, 2005), prior to the referendum on the proposed European constitution. Translated from the French by Julia Kostova.

no and against this yessification is not more violent and more majoritarian.

There is even no need for political conscience in order to have this reflex: it is the return of the automatic flame against the coalition of all those who are on the good side of the universal (while the others are being thrown into the darkness of History). What the powers of the yes and of the Good were wrong about were the perverse effects of the superiority of the Good, and this sort of unconscious lucidity which tells us that one should never prove right somebody who is already right. Already, since Maastricht and April 22, the politically correct forces, be it on the right or on the left, did not want to have anything to do with this quiet dissidence.[2]

This "no" is not at all the result of "negative forces" or of critical thought. It is purely and simply a response in the form of challenge to a hegemonic principle coming from top, for which the people's will is nothing more than an irrelevant parameter, even an obstacle to be overcome. It is clear that for this Europe, conceived according to a model of simulation, which must be projected at all cost onto the real, and to which everyone must adapt, for this virtual Europe, a mere copy of the world power configuration, the populations are only seen as masses that must be annexed willingly or by force to the project in order to serve as its alibi. And those in power are right to be mistrustful of the referendum and all direct expression of political will which, within the framework of a true representation, risks to turn out badly for them. It is then the parliaments which will have to save the operation and back up Europe.

But we are already used to the gap between opinion and political will. It was not that long ago that the Iraq war took place thanks to an international coalition of all powers against the majoritarian, spectacular and verbalized will of all populations. Europe is about to be built exactly on this model. I am surprised, however, that the proponents of the "no" do not make use of this striking example, of this grand opening of the total contempt for the voice of the people.

All this goes well beyond the question of the referendum. It means the failure of the very principle of representation, to the extent where representative institutions no longer function in the "democratic" sense, i.e., from the people and the citizens to the power, but exactly in the opposite direction, from the top to the bottom, passing through the trap of consultation and of a circular game of questions and answers, in which the question responds to itself.

Then, the failure of democracy is in the very heart of the political. And if the electoral system, already shaky because of high abstention rates, must be saved at any cost (before even replying yes, the categorical imperative is to vote at all cost), it is precisely because it functions contrary to true representation, in the forced induction of decisions made "in the name of the people" even though the people thinks the opposite, albeit secretly.

2. Baudrillard refers to the morning after the first round of the French presidential elections of 2002, in which the favored socialists were pushed into third position by the populist supporters of Jean-Marie LePen's National Front.

There is, then, an immediate abreaction to the *pensée unique* of Europe, represented by the yes, a *pensée libérale* of a Europe, which, having failed to invent new rules for the game, can only expand and grow through successive annexations (just like global power). There is then in the refusal of this Europe, the premonition of a much more serious destruction than the establishment of free market and of supranational institutions — the destruction of all true representation, at the end of which all populations will surely be puppets, to whom formal adhesion will be solicited from time to time.

As for the final result, certain suspense remains still: if it is indeed the case, as it seems to be, that the arrogant hegemony of the yes generated the no, then the upsurge in the campaign favoring the yes vote should logically cause a reinforcement of the no vote. But it is not sure that the no stemming from the depths of what were once called the silent majorities, resists a massive intoxication. We could bet that we will head toward a consensual regulation under the spiritual authority of all powers.

Whatever the results, this referendum, stuck between the yes and the no, is only an obstacle. Europe itself is nothing more than an obstacle on the way to a much more serious development — the loss of collective sovereignty — on the horizon of which apprears another profile of the passive or manipulated citizen: the citizen-hostage, the citizen taken hostage by the powers, i.e., the hostage-taking having become the very figure of terrorism — a democractic form — of state terrorism.

On the French Referendum[3]

Alain de Benoist

The referendum in which the French majority rejected the proposed European Constitution was obviously a historical event. But it is not such only because of the results whereby 55 % opposed a confusing text containing not only positive ideas, granted, but also — and mostly — unacceptable propositions. It is historical also, if not even more so, because it shows once again, in a frightening way, the gap that separates the people from the political-mediatic class and its so-called "representatives."

On February 28, 2005, the French deputies at the Congress in Versailles approved the project for the European Constitution with a large majority (91.7 %), a necessary step for the ratification of the treaty. If the decision was made by Parliamentary vote, as was the case in Italy, Germany and Austria, the text, then,

3. This article appeared in *Junge Freiheit* (June 3, 2005). Translated from the French by Julia Kostova.

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